

Beyond Access: What Works in Building Equitable Education Ecosystems

Insights and Innovations from THF-Supported NGOs Working with Underserved Children

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Education as the Cornerstone of Inclusive Development

Development is a multifaceted pursuit encompassing economic growth, healthcare, gender equality, housing, and access to opportunity—but at its very heart lies education. More than a right, education is a foundational enabler that empowers individuals with knowledge, critical thinking, and decision-making capacity, while fostering equity, social mobility, and sustainable development. For underserved populations in particular, quality education serves as a gateway to dignity, agency, and upward mobility.

In India, strides have been made in expanding access to schooling, yet deep disparities persist, particularly among rural, tribal, and economically vulnerable communities. The 2011 Census revealed a significant gender gap in literacy, while recent data from the NSO and Unified District Information System for Education (UDISE) show continued challenges in infrastructure, learning outcomes, and school retention—especially for adolescent girls. As per the Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) 2023, over half of learners aged 14–18 struggle with basic division and reading comprehension. Compounded by the aftershocks of the COVID-19 pandemic, these trends underscore the urgent need for context-sensitive, resilient, and equity-oriented education models.

The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)—specifically SDG 4 on quality education—provide a powerful global framework for addressing these gaps. India has made commendable progress, lifting millions out of multidimensional poverty and improving access to education, yet much work remains to be done to ensure that learning is meaningful, inclusive, and lasting for every child.

Bridging Aspirations and Realities: The Role of Civil Society

Across India, **non-governmental organizations (NGOs)** have stepped in to complement state-led efforts, bringing innovation, reach, and contextual depth to education delivery. From improving foundational literacy and mid-day meal support, to enabling teacher training and integrating life skills, NGOs have consistently adapted to the complex realities faced by marginalized learners.

The work of organizations like **Pratham**, **Teach for India**, **Saath**, and **Akshaya Patra** has demonstrated how partnerships between communities and civil society can transform schools and lives. At present, India is home to **over 3.4 million NGOs**, many of whom work in education—especially in underserved rural and peri-urban contexts. Yet, while their contributions are significant, there is a lack of **systematic documentation of what works, where, and why**—especially in terms of scalability and alignment with national policies.

About This Good Practices Documentation

In this context, **The Hans Foundation (THF)**, through its partnership with over 400 NGOs across 26 states and union territories, has played a catalytic role in improving access to quality education for underprivileged children. THF's support has directly impacted over **10 million lives**, with a strong emphasis on **community participation, inclusion, and learning outcomes**.

This Good Practices Documentation exercise seeks to **identify, capture, and showcase effective models of education** being implemented by THF-supported NGOs across India. The focus is on surfacing approaches that are **inclusive, innovative, and institutionally embedded**—and that have the potential to be scaled across other geographies and systems. Commissioned by THF and carried out by TTC, the documentation uses the **SHARE framework**—a structured methodology drawing from global best practice models (OECD, UNESCO, World Bank). The framework is designed to evaluate good practices through five

lenses: clear objectives, stakeholder engagement, success criteria, data-driven review, and amplification of results.

The Share Framework

S - Set Clear Objectives	H - Holistic Stakeholder Engagement	A - Assess for Criteria Success	R - Review Data and Analyze	E - Enhance and Share Findings
Establishing specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound (SMART) objectives is crucial for guiding the identification of best practices. Clear objectives ensure that the project aligns with community needs and educational goals, facilitating targeted interventions.	Engaging a diverse range of stakeholders—including students, educators, community leaders, and policymakers—enriches the data collection process and ensures that the practices identified are inclusive and relevant. Stakeholder engagement fosters ownership and commitment to the practices being implemented.	Developing criteria based on key dimensions such as effectiveness, sustainability, equity, and adaptability helps evaluate which practices are truly beneficial. These criteria should reflect the specific context of the educational project and the needs of the target population.	Documenting and disseminating identified best practices is essential for promoting knowledge sharing and collaboration. Sharing insights with stakeholders and the broader community facilitates the replication of successful practices and contributes to continuous improvement.	Documenting and disseminating identified best practices is essential for promoting knowledgesharing and collaboration. Sharing insights with stakeholders and the broader community facilitates the replication of successful practices and contributes to continuous improvement.

Using a **rigorous mixed-methods approach**, this Good Practices Documentation combines the depth of qualitative inquiry with the breadth of quantitative analysis to uncover what truly works in delivering quality education to underserved communities. The process involves administering **structured surveys** to students, teachers, and parents, alongside **in-depth field engagements** including **Key Informant Interviews (KIIs)**, **Focus Group Discussions (FGDs)**, and **classroom observations**. These tools allow for a rich, triangulated understanding of each intervention—capturing both measurable outcomes and lived experiences.

Each intervention is assessed against a set of **well-defined criteria** that reflect the multifaceted nature of quality education delivery:

- **Impact on Learning Outcomes, Retention, and Engagement:** Evidence of improved academic performance, reduced dropout rates, and increased student participation.
- **Community Involvement and Local Ownership:** The extent to which parents, youth, and grassroots actors are engaged in sustaining and strengthening education efforts.
- **Innovation and Adaptability:** Use of context-sensitive solutions in pedagogy, delivery, infrastructure, or technology that address real-world challenges.
- **Alignment with Public Systems and Policy Frameworks:** Integration with national/state priorities such as the **National Education Policy (NEP 2020)** and **Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan** to ensure institutional acceptance and sustainability.
- **Cost-Effectiveness and Scalability:** Efficient resource utilization and potential for replication across diverse geographies and populations.

Beyond identifying isolated successes, the documentation seeks to distill **scalable models, replicable strategies, and community-driven innovations** that align with both THF's mission and national education goals. By doing so, it aims to **guide THF's future programmatic investments, foster cross-learning among partner NGOs**, and contribute meaningfully to the **broader discourse on equity and quality in India's education ecosystem**.

This **Good Practices Document** presents a curated set of eight field-tested education interventions supported by THF, implemented by different partner NGOs working across **remote, tribal, and underserved geographies** in India. These interventions, while diverse in their operational models, share a common commitment to **equity, inclusion, and learning outcomes**—and reflect the power of localized solutions in strengthening India's education ecosystem.

Despite being implemented by different NGOs across varied geographies—from tribal hamlets in Rajasthan to underserved communities in West Bengal and Telangana—all eight good practices share a set of **core values and operational strengths**. At the heart of each intervention is a **child-centric, equity-driven approach** that prioritizes foundational learning, emotional well-being, and community participation. These programs are **deeply rooted in local realities**, leveraging low-cost, context-specific solutions to address barriers such as dropout, absenteeism, and learning gaps. A defining characteristic across all models is the **active involvement of parents, community groups, and youth volunteers**, which not only fosters local ownership but ensures sustainability beyond project cycles. Moreover, the practices demonstrate **strong alignment with government policies** like the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and Samagra Shiksha, making them viable for integration into the public system. Through a combination of **innovative pedagogy, inclusive infrastructure, life skills education, and real-time child tracking**, these interventions collectively present a scalable and replicable blueprint for delivering quality education in India's most challenging contexts.

Jan Pahal: A People's Movement for Education in the Heart of Chhattisgarh

Miles from learning: Context for Aspire's intervention

The Power Capital of India-Chhattisgarh beyond its industrial identity, is home to dense forests, and a large section of the population that continues to depend on agriculture and forest produce for sustenance. The tribal pocket in the central region- the Poundiuproda block in the Korba district of Chhattisgarh is marked by complete rurality, dense forests and a tribal population of 72.94%, many of whom belong to particularly vulnerable tribal groups (PVTGs). The communities here are deeply rooted in the natural ecosystem, depending on collection of non-timber forest produced (NTFPs) like Mahua and Tendu leaves for sustenance. Living life in forested hamlets, they are often beyond the reach of formal infrastructure and services.

Efforts have been made to bring children from these communities into the fold of formal education. However, barriers such as distance from schools, lack of transport, cultural disconnect, and limited educational awareness continue to hinder regular enrolment and learning continuity. The Korba block is identified as one of the 115 aspirational districts, which necessitates developmental initiatives like education to bring awareness and economic growth in the region. While modern educational interventions have begun to reach these areas, their impact is still emerging.

According to ASER 2024, only 24.5% of children in Grade III in Chhattisgarh can read a Grade II-level text—highlighting both the access and quality gaps in foundational learning. In such a landscape, interventions that are community-led, inclusive, and adapted to local realities are essential to ensure educational equity and long-term change. For this cause, ASPIRE's *Jan Pahal* program intervenes to bridge the last-mile gap in access to education. Recognizing the importance of integrating traditional values with modern education, the ASPIRE team introduced the “*Jan Pahal*” program. This initiative engages the entire community to underscore the significance of schooling, encourage enrolment to schools, reduce dropouts and build a dedicated force that commits to the goal of “Education for all”.

Children in remote and forested areas of Korba are often excluded from formal education, leaving them vulnerable to child labor, early marriage, and substance abuse. Without Education, many at-risk children remain invisible to protection frameworks. There is an urgent need to streamline these children into schools to safeguard their rights

A People's Movement for Educational Inclusion: The ASPIRE model

ASPIRE, through its intervention across 77 panchayats in this block, has developed a multi-pronged approach to ensure educational access and continuity for all children aged 6-14 years. The Jan Pahal is an initiative designed to address long-standing challenges of school access, retention, and learning outcomes among children in remote, forested, and tribal communities. The program aims to bring **every child into the fold of education** by identifying out-of-school children and supporting their transition into formal schooling through **bridge courses** and **community-led pathways**. Its approach is structured around **three pillars: Access, Learning, and Governance**, with **community mobilisation** at the heart of every intervention.

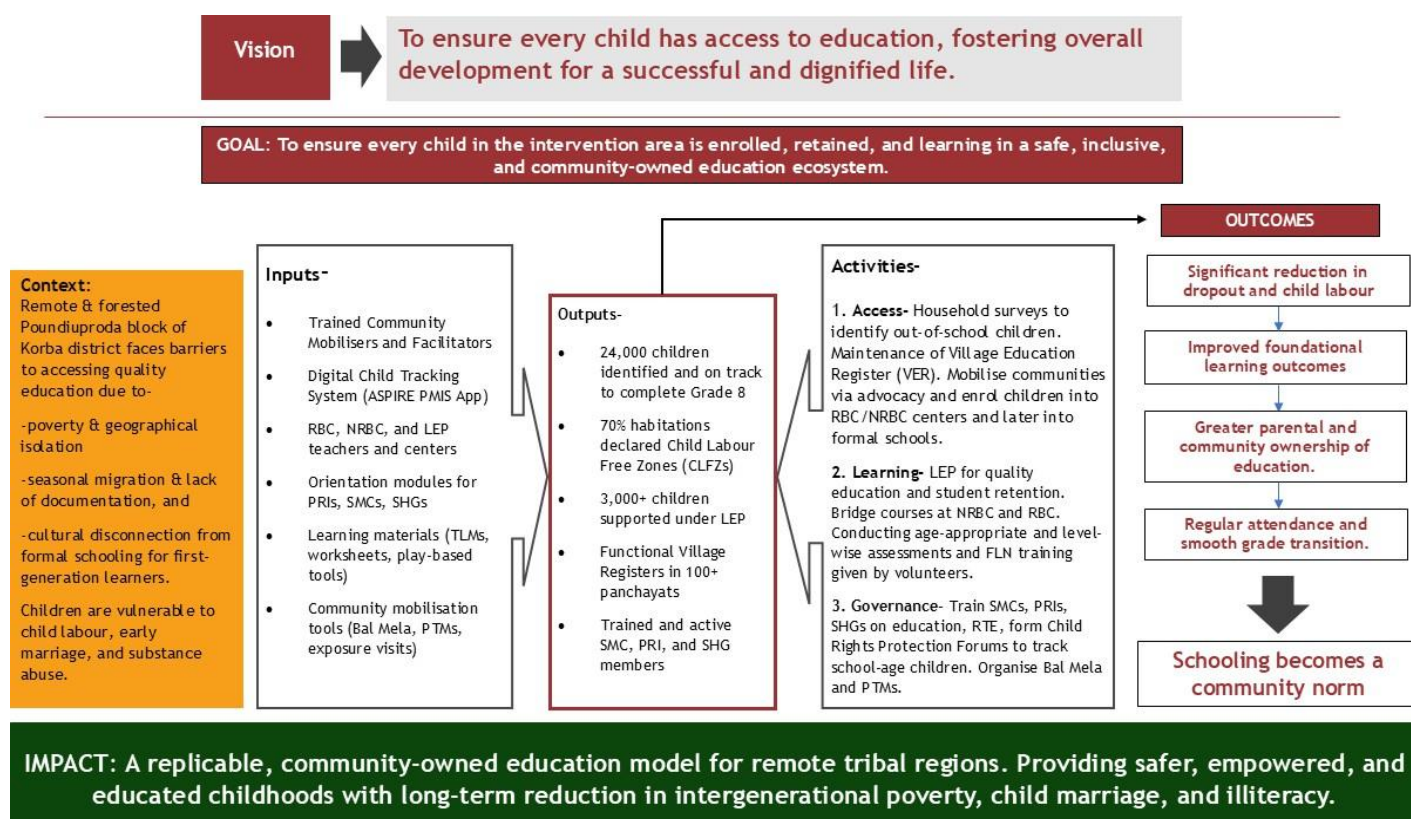
The *Jan Pahal* program takes a **community-driven approach** that powers the entire program and relies on the Child-Tracking System (CTS) to identify vulnerable children to ensure no child is left out. The core strategy involves building the capacity of stakeholders—School Management Committee (SMC) members, panchayat representatives, households, teachers, youth groups, and local volunteers. Through continuous engagement and training, these groups

are encouraged to shift perceptions around education, moving beyond enrolment and transform education into a **shared community priority**.

To support children effectively, *Jan Pahal* includes several key components on the ground:

- **RBCs (Residential Bridge Courses):** For children who have dropped out or never enrolled, helping them catch up academically and transition into formal schools.
- **NRBCs (Non-Residential Bridge Courses):** For children who cannot attend school regularly due to location, domestic responsibilities, or other challenges. These centers offer community-based learning support.
- **LEP (Learning Enhancement Program):** Focused on strengthening in-school education, the intervention works to improve the quality of education and the overall learning environment. LEP teachers are placed in government schools to support the existing teaching staff, which is often inadequate in number.

The Jan Pahal program's best practice of community-led child tracking aligns strongly with several key national education policies. The **Right to Education (RTE) Act, 2009** mandates the formation of School Management Committees (SMCs) with parent representation and prescribes pupil-teacher ratios, which Jan Pahal supports through community engagement and the deployment of LEP teachers. The **Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA 2.0)** provides for Community Mobilisation Funds and encourages tracking mechanisms to identify and support out-of-school children—both of which are central to Jan Pahal's strategy. The **National Education Policy (NEP), 2020** emphasizes the early identification of at-risk children and collaboration with PRIs and local communities, reflecting Jan Pahal's bottom-up approach to governance and inclusion. Additionally, the **NIPUN Bharat Mission** places strong emphasis on foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) and encourages parental engagement and volunteer involvement, directly aligning with the program's model of sustained community participation and real-time tracking at the household level.



Theory of Change-ASPIRE

From Margins to Mainstream- Features of a Scalable System

SMART Pathways for transformational outcomes

The Jan Pahal program envisions a community free from child labour, substance abuse, and early marriage, by enrolling and retaining every out-of-school child through the transformative power of education. To ensure that this vision translates into measurable impact, the program adopts a SMART goals framework—goals that are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound. Community mobilisers (CMs), who are selected from within the local tribal communities, conduct door-to-door surveys with the help of real-time tracking PMIS app and maintain a village education register, not only identifying out-of-school children but also mapping their psychosocial realities and household contexts, which are crucial for sustainable enrolment and retention. Their deep-rooted understanding of local lifestyles and belief systems allows them to build trust and offer culturally sensitive solutions, significantly improving the achievability of the program's objectives. The program's design is highly relevant, aligning with national priorities under the NEP 2020 and Samagra Shiksha, particularly in terms of enrolling out-of-school

SMART Framework at a Glance-

- **Specific-** Targets out-of-school children between the age of 6-14 years through tracking and intensive outreach.
- **Measurable-** Progress is measured through the enrolment, attendance, assessments and Grade transition data via **Village Education Registers (VERs)**.
- **Achievable-** Goals are grounded in evidence from tracking apps, VERs & community structures like PRIs, SMCs, and SHGs.
- **Relevant-** addresses key issues: **child labour, dropouts, learning deficits, and school governance**, which are core to the project's mission and aligned with RTE and SDG 4 (Quality Education).
- **Time-bound-** Outputs are defined within the program's implementation cycle (often 2-3 years), with yearly activity milestones and ongoing monitoring.

children, promoting Foundational Literacy and Numeracy (FLN), and establishing strong monitoring and tracking systems to achieve inclusive, quality education for all.

Creating a Schooling Ecosystem Through Community-Led Interventions:

The core of ASPIRE's implementation strategy lies in mobilizing the community to recognize education as a shared responsibility. The process is designed to ensure that every child is identified, supported, and retained within the education system through a full-circle approach:

Community Mobilization as the Entry Point: The process begins with extensive community engagement involving PRIs, SMCs, SHG members, youth volunteers, and households. Mobilizers are selected from within the community and trained to lead dialogue, awareness sessions, and household visits—establishing trust and buy-in from the ground up. This includes partnering with SMCs, liaising with officials, MLAs, and Sarpanch to secure buildings for safe and free use as RBC centers for children

Innovation in Tracking:

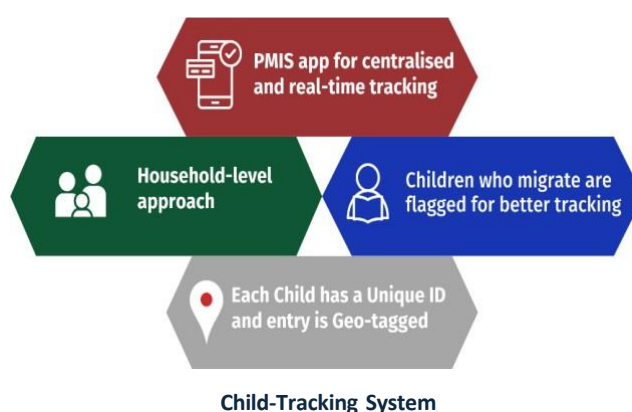
The Child Tracking System (CTS), developed by ASPIRE and implemented across 77 panchayats in Korba, is an innovative, community-led, tech-enabled solution that goes beyond tracking enrolment. What sets it apart is its integration of a detailed household survey capturing both educational status and psychosocial vulnerabilities—such as migration, orphanhood, disability, or home-based responsibilities—allowing for sensitive, child-specific planning.

Conducted through the ASPIRE PMIS app by trained local mobilisers, the system creates a real-time, single-source database and links every child to the most appropriate intervention—whether it's an RBC, NRBC, LEP teacher, or hostel support. Mobilisers maintain village registers, facilitate follow-ups, and act as bridges between families and schools, ensuring the data directly informs program decisions and government coordination. By rooting data in community trust and contextual understanding, CTS becomes a powerful tool for ensuring inclusive, last-mile educational access.

Categorization and Identification of Needs: Children are categorized based on challenges such as migration, disability, forest-based isolation, lack of documentation, or home responsibilities. This categorization helps in designing targeted interventions for each group. The enrolment plan database is created after the household survey is conducted to identify the areas where each child needs help and a solution is prescribed according to the challenge. The baseline is conducted which helps in level-wise categorisation for enrolment using baseline scores- L0 (0-20), L1(20-50), L2 (above 50).

Bridge and Alternate Learning Centers: Based on tracking data, Residential and Non-Residential Bridge Courses (RBCs/NRBCs) are established in areas with concentrated dropout or out-of-school populations. These centers provide transitional education to prepare children for formal school entry.

LEP (Learning Enhancement Program) Support: In schools with high enrolment and teacher shortages, LEP teachers are deployed to maintain the RTE-prescribed 30:1 ratio as well as provide quality training through play-based learning, engagement methods to prevent further



dropouts. The LEP is run at 52 centres covering 1,961 students and focuses on a strategy for motivating students at school to maintain continuation and improve learning outcomes.

Mainstreaming and Continuous Monitoring: Once children are ready, they are enrolled into nearby government schools. Mobilizers continue to track attendance, learning levels, and socio-emotional well-being to prevent dropouts.

Feedback Loops and Local Ownership: Regular review meetings with panchayats, schools, and community stakeholders are conducted to evaluate progress, address gaps, and strengthen accountability. The goal is to embed education as a long-term community priority, beyond the duration of external interventions.

Crafting support structures for enhanced outcomes-

1. **FLN Volunteers** join the Jan Pahal Program and provide after school FLN training to ensure that students attain grade-level competencies and do not fall behind on the basics after getting mainstreamed.
2. **Teacher Training/Capacity Building-** Conducted Teacher training on the relevance of formal school education, community outreach initiatives, exposure visits from out-of-state officials to showcase the success of similar initiatives in other states, and curriculum reform through incorporating teaching-learning material and technology integration.
3. **Exposure Visit to ASPIRE's intervention areas like Odisha:** organized to deepen community participation and build awareness among Panchayati Raj Institution (PRI) members. These visits are designed to introduce participants to successful education models and equip them with practical knowledge to support similar efforts in their own villages

Supporting Interventions

Community-Powered: A cost-effective solution to Inclusion: The ASPIRE model evaluated against the outcomes, resource use and scalability, presents itself as an extremely cost-effective model. It is designed to be resource-efficient and community-anchored, leveraging existing infrastructure, local human resources, and community ownership to minimize costs while maximizing impact. Residential Bridge Courses (RBCs), Non-Residential Bridge Courses (NRBCs) and Learning Enhancement Programs (LEPs) run in community spaces and government schools, avoiding parallel systems. The Child Tracking System (CTS), though an initial investment, provides long-term value through real-time data, household-level mapping, and dropout prevention. The model's sustainability is reinforced by its integration with local governance systems and the potential for mobilising community contributions, making it a cost-conscious, replicable approach to last-mile education delivery. Crafting support structures for enhanced outcomes. 1. FLN Volunteers join the Jan Pahal Program and provide after school FLN training to ensure that students attain grade-level competencies and do not fall behind on the basics after getting mainstreamed. 2. Teacher Training/Capacity Building- Conducted Teacher training on the relevance of formal school education, community outreach initiatives, exposure visits from out-of-state officials to showcase the success of similar initiatives in other states, and curriculum reform through incorporating teaching-learning material and technology integration. 3. Exposure Visit to ASPIRE's intervention areas like Odisha: organized to deepen community participation and build awareness among Panchayati Raj Institution (PRI) members. These visits are designed to introduce participants to successful education models and equip them with practical knowledge to support similar efforts in their own villages. From external evaluation report of our Jan Pahal programme in Korba.

Glimpse of Innovation- Bal Mela: Creating Community Pride Through Celebration of Learning

Bal Mela is an innovative approach to deepen community engagement in children's education by transforming it into a shared celebration. Unlike traditional Parent-Teacher Meetings, which often see limited participation, Bal Melas are inclusive events that bring together parents, panchayat members, SMCs, youth, and the wider village community.

These vibrant gatherings serve as a platform for children to showcase their learning through stalls, performances, games, recitals, and creative displays—turning education into a source of pride and joy. The excitement and visibility around the event generate a positive outlook on schooling, encourage consistent attendance, and significantly contribute to reducing dropout rates. In many villages, the Bal Mela has become the most anticipated event of the year, reinforcing the value of education in a fun, participatory way.

Bal Mela- Innovation in practice

Anchored in Evidence: The Key to Scaling Impact and Success

The project's Monitoring and Evaluation framework is designed to track progress across three core objectives: **universal school enrolment**, **foundational learning outcomes**, and **community-led school governance**. It follows a clear **Results-Based Management (RBM) structure**, linking objectives to specific outputs and activities. Each activity is measurable, time-bound, and focused on either child-level outcomes or systemic change.

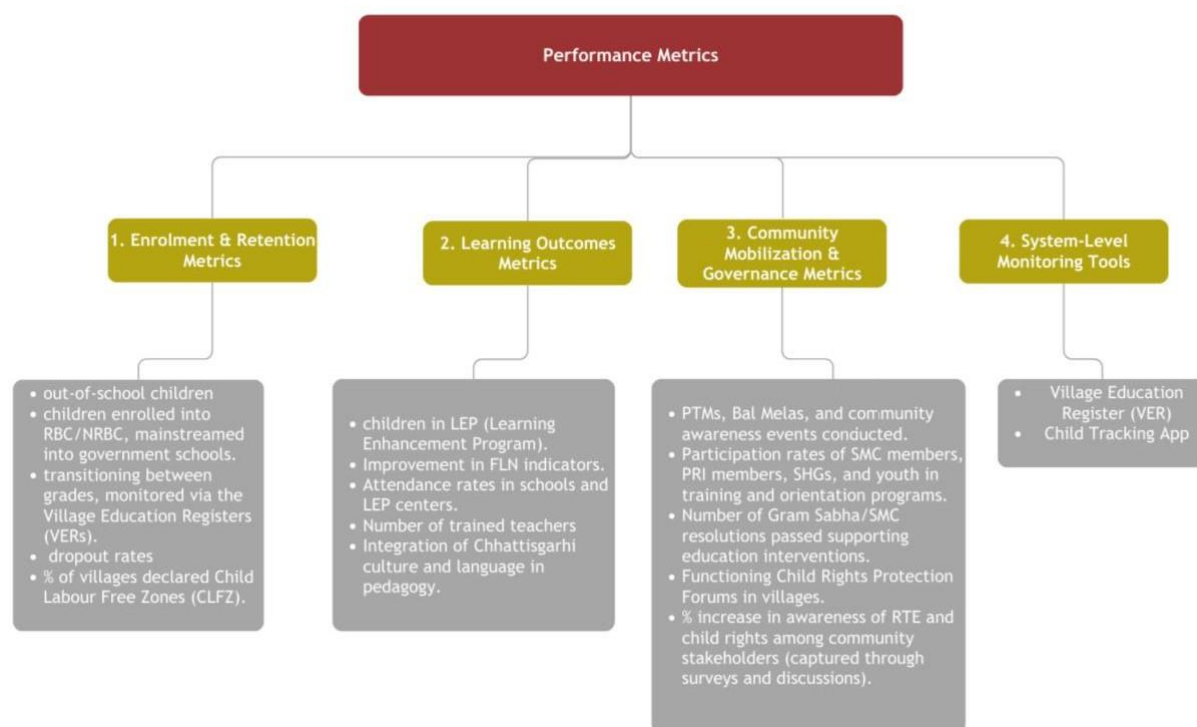
What the Framework Contains-

- **Clear Logical Flow:** The M&E framework follows a logical hierarchy from objectives to outputs and activities. For instance, activities such as child tracking, LEP implementation, and SMC training are aligned with larger goals such as enrolment, learning, and governance.
- **Quantifiable Outputs:** Targets like enrolling 24,000 out-of-school children or covering 3,000 students under LEP are defined clearly, allowing for tangible progress tracking.
- **Community-Based Monitoring Tools:** The use of Village Education Registers (VERs), Child Rights Protection Forums, and regular grade transition monitoring ensures data is updated from the ground and is reflective of actual field conditions.
- **Pedagogical Integration Tracking:** The integration of local knowledge systems, digital tools, and teacher training is monitored as part of improving classroom quality and learning outcomes.
- **Norm Creation Indicators:** The framework goes beyond outputs to foster norm-setting — such as creating Child Labour Free Zones (CLFZs) and encouraging formal resolutions from Gram Sabhas.

Strengths of the M&E Framework-

1. **Community Ownership:** By engaging PRI members, SMCs, SHGs, and youth in both data collection and intervention design, the framework builds accountability at the grassroots.
2. **Real-Time and Localized Tracking:** The use of child tracking app- ASPIRE PMIS and village registers ensures that no child is left out and real-time data can drive timely interventions.
3. **Holistic Measurement:** The framework covers both **access** (enrolment, attendance), **Learning** (learning outcomes), and **governance** (training and awareness of PRIs and SMCs), providing a 360-degree view of the intervention.

4. **Cultural Relevance:** Inclusion of local languages, traditions, and art forms in pedagogy makes both the intervention and the evaluation more contextually grounded.



Mapping performance metrics

Redefining Possibilities: The Transformative Impact of Mobilisation and Tracking

The initiative has shown impressive progress, reflected in both the reduction of out-of-school children and the increase in overall educational participation across various communities. The program has made a transformative impact on the community, driving substantial changes in critical indicators of educational success and child well-being. A remarkable 80% reduction in the dropout rate signifies that children are not only staying in school but thriving in their educational journey, defying the odds that once pushed them out. Simultaneously, there has been a 50% decline in child marriage, illustrating how the program has become a powerful force in delaying early marriage by providing children with the opportunity and motivation to stay in school. The battle against child labor has also seen a major victory, with an 80% drop in child labor, ensuring that children are now more likely to be found in classrooms rather than in the workforce. School enrollment has surged by an impressive 90%, reflecting the program's success in reaching previously marginalized children and integrating them into the formal education system. Furthermore, the initiative has led to a 90-95% increase in daily school attendance, signaling not only greater access to education but also a supportive, engaging environment that encourages children to attend school regularly. These outcomes collectively demonstrate the success of mobilization and tracking, in creating a system where education is a shared responsibility of the entire community. By ensuring that every person is accountable for the education of village children, the program has made education the norm.

Impact in numbers

- **Only 24 children** remain out of school across **77 panchayats**, marking a significant drop from earlier numbers.

Over 600 children have been successfully mainstreamed into government schools through RBCs, NRBCs, and mobilization efforts.
281 SMC members oriented and trained.
7455 Children are the part of FLN Programme
More than 3,000 households are now part of a structured village register and tracked database, ensuring real-time visibility of children.

Way Forward: Resilience for Systemic Change

The ASPIRE model has demonstrated consistent progress, highlighting the power of community-led tracking in creating an enabling environment driven by shared responsibility and a singular vision. It has acted as the backbone of the model, mobilizing remote locations and connecting them through a unified thread, instilling hope and motivating children to reshape their futures and redefine possibilities. There has been a remarkable 80% reduction in dropout rates and an 80% decline in child labor, underscoring the model's impact on transforming lives. While challenges exist due to the terrain, these can be addressed through wrap-around solutions that integrate with existing support structures, ensuring that barriers are overcome and the model can continue to reach its full potential.

- Formalising Mobilisation to Overcome Resistance to Change:** Resistance from tribal communities can be addressed by institutionalising community mobilisation as a core education strategy. Assigning formal roles to PRIs, SHGs, and SMCs in mobilisation and school governance through amendments in Panchayati Raj and education rules will build trust and ensure sustained, locally led advocacy for education.
- Linkage to Residential Schemes for Overflow and Remote Cases:** For students who cannot be accommodated in RBCs due to space limitations or who live in extremely remote locations, linking them to existing government residential schemes—such as Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalayas (KGBVs), Ashram Shalas, or Eklavya Model Residential Schools—can provide an alternative, stable schooling environment. This ensures that lack of space does not become a barrier to access, especially for vulnerable children who require a safe, long-term residential learning setup.
- Digitally Strengthening CTS to Counter Bureaucratic Delays:** To overcome documentation hurdles and enrolment bottlenecks, community-generated CTS data should be integrated with formal systems like the State Education MIS and Aspirational District Dashboard. This ensures faster validation, smoother mainstreaming, and accurate targeting of services for undocumented and at-risk children.
- Planning for Environmental Disruptions through Localized Resilience Models:** In areas like the Lemru elephant corridor, where communities face both human-wildlife conflict and climate-related disruptions, resilience planning must be rooted in local knowledge and experience. A strong example of this is seen in the transition of *Hathi Mitras*—villagers trained by the Forest Department to educate residents on elephant behavior—into Community Mobilisers under the ASPIRE program. Because of their previous role, these mobilisers were already well-versed in managing human-elephant interactions. So, when families expressed hesitation about sending their children to school due to elephant movements, these mobilisers were able to provide immediate, practical solutions and training to households. This dual expertise highlights how integrated,

community-led approaches can strengthen localized education resilience plans and address environmental disruptions more effectively

Going to the last mile ensures that no child is overlooked and receives the personalized support they need. The program has turned its vision into reality, advocating for education that transforms the future of children, dismantling cycles of exploitation, and opening doors to a brighter, more equitable tomorrow.

Voices from the Field

Building a Village of Dreamers: One Ratalal at a Time

Ratalal Ji, a concerned father from Bodanala village, had one wish: to give his daughter, Durgeshwari, a better future. He knew that education was the key, but in a village where fishing and forest produce like mahua, char fruits, and tendu leaves were the main sources of livelihood, education had never been a priority.

With ASPIRE's intervention, the School Management Committee (SMC) began holding monthly meetings to track each child's progress and visited the families of absent children to encourage their return. The community also launched an anti-alcohol campaign, putting an end to the illegal liquor trade that had long hindered their progress. Samaylal, the senior ward representative, reflected, "When we saw improvements in school attendance and learning, we realized we had the power to transform our village."

ASPIRE strengthened 254 SMCs across Chhattisgarh, training 3,256 members to advocate for children's education. Today, Bodanala stands as a testament to the power of collective effort and community ownership. Ratalal Ji's dream for his daughter's education has become a shared vision, proving that small, unified steps can lead to extraordinary change.

A New Beginning- Shivani's Story

Shivani, a 10-year-old girl, is the eldest of five siblings. Born to Naresh Ram Agriya, who only completed second grade, and Bhagwati Bai, an illiterate homemaker, Shivani's life was shaped by hardship. Originally from Moraga Panchayat, her family moved to Tadapkhna in search of work, where her father crafts iron tools, and her mother gathers and sells forest products to make ends meet.



Shivani at RBC centre

Shivani spent her days grazing cattle with her younger sister, Sandhya, and caring for her younger siblings. Education seemed out of reach, as her parents hadn't enrolled any of their children in school, and they lived far from the nearest school.

That changed when LEP teacher Anita Markam visited their home and encouraged Shivani's parents to enroll her in the Balika Awasik Setu Pathshala in Rampur. Shivani was hesitant, worried about being in a new place and failing to learn. But Anita reassured her, saying, "At

our hostel, we'll teach you with love, and no one will scold you." With this encouragement, Shivani joined the RBC.

When Shivani arrived, she was welcomed with open arms by the other children, and soon, she was not only learning but thriving. Within months, she became passionate about her studies and even began teaching new students. "We never expected a girl who had never been to school to become so dedicated," said her RBC teacher, Pinky Madam.

ASPIRE's monthly meetings with parents helped guide families like Shivani's in enrolling children in schools and obtaining necessary documents. With their help, Shivani got her birth certificate and Aadhaar card. In 2025, Shivani will be admitted to 6th grade under the RTE Act, marking the start of a new, brighter future. Her journey is a powerful testament to the impact of education and community support.

Turning the Tide: Manoj Kumar's Journey Back to School

Manoj Kumar, 13, from the Baiga tribe in Chhattisgarh, faced hardship early on with the loss of his father and limited family support. He lived with his mother, older brother (who dropped out after third grade), younger brother, and other family members in a remote village. The school is 3.5 km away, and the path passes through the jungle. Because of this, Manoj Kumar's admission was done in the Madia Kashar village's Primary School Damamuda. However, he was not admitted at the age of 6, but rather at the age of 8, and he used to go to school from his aunt's house. Manoj Kumar was quite good at studies, and even though his family did not encourage him, he did self-study at home.

He attended school regularly until the third grade. However, he fell into bad company, spending time with friends who never went to school and worked in the jungle. Gradually, he left education behind, herding cattle, hunting birds, and fishing, eventually dropping out. Two years later, Kalawati Ji from Aspire identified Manoj and other out-of-school children, and after family verification, Manoj was enrolled in Aspire's Setu Curriculum Center in June 2023. Though initially homesick and battling old habits, Manoj began to adapt through creative lessons and rhymes.

In August 2024, based on his age and skill, he was admitted to the Government Pre-Secondary School in Macha Doli, where he attends school while staying at the RBC. Living at the RBC, his progress has been remarkable. The school headmaster regularly praises his improvement, with Manoj consistently ranking among the top students in tests and exams, proving that with support and determination, a fresh start is possible.